

The Reflection

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Synopsis: A detective investigates disappearances inside an old power station which serves as a gateway to an oneiric world existing beyond our plane of reality.

Characters:

- Detective Chris Miller
- Charlotte Miller
- Diane Miller
- Glen Santoro
- Maggie Pierce
- Shawn Pierce
- Paul Myles
- Olivia
- Captain Ross
- Old Albert
- The Count
- The Grease Monkey

Plot:

Prologue

At an art exhibition almost two centuries ago, a Count presents his newest painting, a harrowing depiction of the town on fire along with charred corpses at the centerstage of the devastation. Most of the visitors are repulsed by such a bleak artwork, save for one captivated man.

The Count approaches him and the man asks about his inspiration behind such an unflinching piece of art. The Count claims he saw the conflagration in his dreams. Intrigued, the man asks his friend, “Monkey”, to take a look at the painting. Upon seeing Monkey, The Count is stunned. He says he saw him in his dreams of the fiery blaze and even immortalized him, albeit as a tiny figure, within the canvas. Monkey, a little embarrassed, suggests The Count might be mistaking him for someone else.

At night in his castle, The Count is abruptly roused from his sleep, his heart pounding fearfully. He hears his wife screaming in her bedroom and dashes to her. It turns out both The Count and his wife experienced a shared nightmare wherein they relived the traumatic death of their son, who died in a fire years ago. Amidst their grief, they hear a chillingly familiar voice from below, “Mother! Father!” echoing through the castle. It is clearly their son’s... Perhaps a specter? With only a candlestick, The Count, frightened, makes his way down the stairs where the scent of burned human flesh haunts the air.

The ground floor, however, reveals no source for the voice, which has now fallen silent. Through the windows, he finds a horde of people assembling at the gates whilst a mist slowly begins to swallow the castle. When The Count goes there to investigate, his own **doppelganger** emerges from the crowd and ominously announces, “A fire may bring him back.” As The Count eyeballs his own double in horror, his wife, in the castle, utters a spine-chilling scream just as the mist completely engulfs the building...

Part 1 - Rivermouth

In present days, Rivermouth is a flourishing and prosperous town. Visitors don't come for the beautiful mountains or spellbinding forests, they come for **The Reach**. The Reach is a mysterious realm, existing beyond our material plane of existence, accessible only via an old power station where the consciousnesses of the people inside are transported to this world and experience what can be best described as a collective dream. This unique phenomenon has made Rivermouth a place of fascination and mystery, attracting those willing to experience the inexplicable wonders of The Reach.

One quiet night, Shawn Pierce enters a bar for his usual late night drinking but he seems suspiciously nervous. His boots are covered in mud and he is sweating profusely. He joins his colleague, Glen Santoro. Shawn is frustrated at his crumbling marriage with his wife, Maggie, whom he accuses of infidelity. Both men work as guides mandatory for tourists who want to visit The Reach. Shawn has an assignment tonight and he hates his job due to its mundane and tiresome nature whilst Glen finds The Reach to be the only place where he doesn't feel alienated. Glen, a lifelong existentialist, feels like all his life he has been acting inauthentically (as per **Sartre's bad faith**) and he loathes himself for that. However inside The Reach, his deepest desires often materialize before his eyes, allowing him to peer into his unconscious and sometimes relish in forbidden cravings. Moreover, acting as guide gives him a sense of purpose in an otherwise lonesome and aimless existence. Shawn is a guide solely for the money and doesn't care much for The Reach's mysteries or purpose, if it even has one.

Later during the night, Shawn walks into a dense forest. At its center lies the famous power station. A police border encircles the station whilst giant light poles illuminate the place. He meets his client, Paul Myles, who has brought with him a second client, nicknamed The Grease Monkey ('Monkey' in the **prologue**). He wears greasy clothes similar to those of a mechanic and remains perfectly silent. Since Paul initially said there would only be himself, Shawn refuses to guide The Grease Monkey since he hates last minute changes. But Paul promises to double his friend's payment and Shawn reluctantly caves in. Police Captain Ross, a friend of Shawn's, informs him that Maggie is looking for him. But Shawn is actively ignoring her, asking Ross to disregard her calls. There are almost 50 tourists inside the power station, all with their respective guides. When the clock strikes midnight, a mist engulfs the building and within the haze, mysterious lights begin to flicker. Everyone inside falls asleep whilst their consciousness is transported inside The Reach.

Meanwhile, the inside of Shawn's house is in complete shambles. Maggie, visibly distressed, leaves and goes to her paramour's place. She has been cheating on Shawn with Alex for quite a while now due to her unhappy marriage. Once she reaches Alex's house, she finds that the door has been forced open. In his bedroom, she finds a handgun lying on the bed with a large amount of blood on the pillows. Deeply unsettled, she leaves.

At the bar, Glen is intensely inebriated. He approaches a woman in a red coat which triggers a surge of memories of a past lover he still longs for. She projects his unfulfilled desires into the stranger and makes unwanted advances. The woman obviously refuses and when her boyfriend arrives at the scene, they get into a fistfight. The boyfriend breaks Glen's nose and the drunken Glen is thrown out of the bar. Outside, he breaks down in tears over the persistent loneliness tainting his life.

Maggie sees Glen and doesn't even attempt to comfort him. She just asks where her husband is and Glen, barely able to form a coherent sentence, lets out that Shawn is at The Reach. But it's already past midnight and thus, she is refused access into the power station. A journey inside The Reach normally lasts 8 hours but in the morning, way past this window, everyone has woken up, except for Shawn and Paul. Maggie's anxiety escalates but Ross tries to reassure her that the two will wake up anytime now. But when dusk settles in, it becomes apparent something is wrong. Even Captain Ross acknowledges this is flagrantly unusual. Remembering that a third man, The Grease Monkey, also accompanied them, Ross mobilizes his team to find him since he seemed to have physically disappeared inside the power station.

Shawn's and Paul's unconscious bodies are carried out of the building. The power station only serves as an entry point into The Reach, even if someone is dragged outside, they will still be able to wake up once the 8 hours have passed. But for Shawn and Paul, this is troublingly not the case. An ambulance arrives to carry them to a hospital where they can be fed intravenously. Captain Ross is very well aware of previous disappearances and knows it's extremely rare for them to return once the 8 hours window has passed. Maggie stares powerlessly as Paul and Shawn are taken away, despondent and muddled.

Next morning, Ross visits Maggie, who has been by her husband's side all night. Ross' attempts to comfort her have proven futile. The Captain then drives to the local aerodrome where Detective Chris Miller has just landed. The detective's demeanor is that of a very confident and grounded man. They visit The Mayor of Rivermouth, a greedy capitalist. Chris correctly deduces that this isn't the first time people have disappeared inside The Reach and asks The Mayor why the power station hasn't been demolished or closed down. The Mayor cites John Stuart Mill's utilitarianism to justify this, namely that economic growth stemming from Rivermouth's tourism has led to a more prosperous town, which favors the happiness and well-being of most inhabitants even if some incidents, like the disappearances, are inevitable. He mentions that since the **1854 fire**, nothing significant happened in Rivermouth until the discovery of The Reach.

Chris has never been to The Reach but accepted this assignment because of Paul, a once colleague and good friend of his. Ross informs him about the third man, The Grease Monkey, who somehow physically disappeared inside the power station. Cameras inside only recorded static making the third man's disappearance all the more troubling. A proponent of rationalism, Chris objects to the abstract and supernatural nature of The Reach. He is strongly against empiricism, believing our senses only provide a mental construct of reality similar to how The Reach could be a creation of the collective unconscious, lacking any tangible connection to the external world. The Reach's dreamlike nature violates Plato's rationalist ideals and cannot be reconciled with his **theory of forms** due to its subjective nature. To Chris, any insights or experiences derived from The Reach are thus

inherently flawed, as they are based on dream logic and personal experiences. The Mayor, offended by Chris' criticisms, concludes their meeting, believing Chris is merely another snobbish and ignorant cynic. He recommends Glen Santoro as guide of his investigation, much to Ross' objections, who only views Glen as a stupid drunk.

At the hospital, Glen stares despondently at the unconscious Shawn, saddened by his condition. When Glen claims to relate to Maggie's sorrow, she lambasts him for it and begs him not to mention "Olivia" again. Chris comes in to question Maggie and Glen but Maggie's bluntness is a clear indication she isn't in the right state of mind for a chat. Chris instead invites Glen for breakfast. During their conversation, Glen reveals he was close to Shawn since they both started working as guides 6 years ago. He insists Shawn isn't the type to have enemies, making his disappearance all the more puzzling. Glen reveals there's a river in The Reach and anyone who ever crossed to the other side rarely came back. Even those who did are trapped in a persistent vegetative state. However, Glen doubts an experienced guide like Shawn would make such a rookie mistake.

At around 22:00, an exhausted Maggie returns home and cleans all the mess. Afterwards, she jumps on her bed, still in a state of despondency, and contemplates on her life with Shawn, more specifically, her wrongdoings. Outside, there's a huge downpour. From her window, Maggie sees the silhouette of a strange man, face obscured, in a dark raincoat stalking her from her backyard. She goes downstairs and exits her house only to find that the mysterious man has vanished. She grabs a torch and goes to the place where he was standing and sees a slight variation of the soil's texture, as if something has been buried there. She picks a shovel and begins excavating until she strikes something and finds blood on the shovel's blade. She hit a body and much to her horror, it's Alex's. Maggie is sickened to find a sizable bullet hole right on the corpse's forehead. Suddenly, a police car parks in front of her house. She panics and swiftly buries back the body.

Chris repeatedly knocks on her door before Maggie answers. Through Chris' cleverly structured questions, Maggie slips out that she was cheating on Shawn due to an intense dissatisfaction with her married life. Chris finds Maggie's infidelity puzzling since she admitted that Shawn was never abusive and always provided for her. But Maggie retorts she was simply bored and increasingly dissatisfied with their marriage. She misinterprets Nietzsche's philosophy that hints towards monogamy being a social construct and that individuals should create their own values. But Chris, cringing at Maggie's attempts to philosophize her affair, retorts that Sartre would view infidelity as an act of bad faith, an evasion of one's freedom and responsibility. She lambasts Maggie's unfaithfulness and asks her if she now recognizes her husband's true value, now that he's gone. Shawn and her had their first fight when he found out she had a lover but she keeps Alex's murder to herself, knowing that could implicate Shawn. Chris wants to talk to Maggie's lover but Maggie claims Alex and Shawn never knew each other and her lover left town weeks before Shawn's disappearance. Chris' inability to understand Maggie's infidelity greatly frustrates him but knowing she wasn't inside the power station on the night of her husband's disappearance, she's obviously not a suspect. He thus leaves her alone and picks up Glen before heading towards the power station.

Chris is stunned by the popularity of The Reach. Though he heard about it, witnessing it for the first time leaves him baffled. They stumble across Old Albert, who recounts how he and three other men worked at the power station when one night, a strange mist engulfed the place. But once it dissipated, they found themselves in another world. Inside, dead people and memories were revived in sometimes cathartic and horrifying ways. This is how The Reach was discovered. Among the 3 other men, one died of old age, another disappeared in The Reach weeks after its discovery, and the last one, nicknamed The Grease Monkey, left town the morning of their first journey into The Reach, never to be seen again. Hearing that name again arouses Chris' curiosity about the third man who disappeared with Shawn and Paul.

Around 15 minutes before midnight, Chris investigates the interior of the power station and finds a strange tunnel in the basement. Old Albert begs him not to venture there, claiming he once saw "an evil reflection" inside. But Chris interprets his words as just some old man's gibberish and goes in nevertheless. Strange noises haunt the tunnel as it reaches a left turn. Heavy breathings are heard on the other side of the turn and Chris pulls out a gun. Chris slowly approaches it, scared to discover what's on the other side but suddenly Glen's voice echoes through the tunnel, "Chris, it's time!" Chris goes to him and somehow fearful, he asks if his gun will be transported into The Reach. Glen reassures him that as long as he carries it with him, an image of it will also be projected into The Reach. At midnight, the mist arrives and begins flooding the interior of the power station. The clouds remain at knee level. Mysterious lights flash through the building and after a few minutes, the mist dissipates and bright rays of sunlight fly through the windows, illuminating the wide room. **They are in The Reach.**

Bemused, Chris steps out of the power station and finds an ethereal, distorted, and multicolored sky reminiscent of post-impressionist paintings. Unlike Glen, Chris feels profoundly alienated by this new environment. A field surrounds the power station with a forest encircling it. As they venture further, they find a train station amidst the trees, which Glen theorizes is a manifestation of one of the visitors' memories. Glen posits that The Reach is a sentient being and like any intelligence, it's curious, which explains why The Reach loves to peer into the unconscious of its visitors. They then stumble on a church where a newborn is being baptized. Chris cannot quite fathom the inexplicable nature of this dream world but Glen says people don't come for answers, they come for the experience. They also encounter a faceless man in a seemingly vegetative state and Glen says he isn't a visitor but instead an image created by one of the visitors; aka a memory they have of someone. A face will appear and the image will regain awareness once whoever created them interacts with them.

Chris notices a plume of smoke ascending into the sky. Drawn to the source, he arrives at a blazing house, a familiar one. As a crowd gathers around the fire, Chris urgently attempts to persuade them to keep their distances. Glen, however, is able to calm him down and leads him towards the notorious river, known ominously for the fact that those who cross it never return. On the riverbank, a middle-aged man and his young girlfriend inform them that there were indeed 3 men who ventured to the other side of the river on the day of Shawn's, Paul's and The Grease Monkey's disappearance. The man relayed this information to the authorities but the fact this wasn't even passed on to Chris makes him question the reliability of the local police. When it becomes

apparent that the two are at the riverbank for sex and the young woman is seemingly underaged, Glen quickly reassures Chris that she is merely an image.

The multicolored sky succumbs to an enveloping darkness solely illuminated by some mesmerizing auroras, all whilst an eldritch mist shrouds the forest. A crowd assembles around it in great anticipation. It's the zone of resurrections. Naked figures, images manufactured by the visitors' memories of the dead, emerge from the mist. Although the resurrected ones were not exactly the same as their original selves, the crowd was still overwhelmed with tears and joy by their reunions with the deceased. Chris precipitates into the mist screaming, "Charlotte! Charlotte!" but to no avail. Glen explains that feelings like guilt and resentment might prevent resurrections and a perturbed Chris asks to be left alone for a while. He wanders forlornly through the trees, pondering on his dark past.

Meanwhile, in a completely different part of the forest, Glen walks as if he is looking for something or rather, someone. A faint voice echoes "I'm here," and Glen sees a beautiful woman in a red dress strolling through the trees. Entranced, he follows her into a castle amidst the trees (the same castle as The Count's in the **prologue**). At the same time, a sorrowful Chris sees the figure of a 12 years old girl and chases her as she enters a house which looks exactly like the burning house previously seen but this time, it's bafflingly intact. She dashes through the corridors and locks herself into her room. Chris begs her to open it...

Glen chases the red dress lady through the wide interiors of the castle and in the main hall, he is horrified to find dozens of charred human remains. The lady stops amidst this nauseating scene and gestures seductively towards Glen, drawing him closer. Just as he's about to kiss her, Chris breaks open the door at the house and finds himself inexplicably in the castle's hall, facing Glen and the lady. She promptly disappears into nothingness whilst the 12 years old girl is nowhere to be seen. Glen glares at Chris in anger for ruining his moment before he's suddenly woken up back to reality. Chris then dashes to the burning house and amidst its detritus, he finds the burnt remains of a little girl, whose carbonized layer of skin is detaching from her body. The horrified Chris is then propelled back to reality.

Like each morning, the atmosphere is charged with emotions. Chris is among the dejected ones, disturbed by what he's seen inside and the fact that they all stemmed from his unconscious. Chris was looking for his sister, Charlotte, aged 12 when she passed away after their family house burned down with her inside. Similarly, the red dress lady is revealed to be Glen's wife, Olivia, who also died in tragic circumstances which Glen refuses to get into. Glen begs Chris to forget the past but Chris, sensing the hypocrisy of his words, retorts that Glen's interactions with Olivia is proof he hasn't moved on either. Glen, as usual, drowns his sorrows with whiskey whilst Chris tries to stop his recent experiences from getting the better of him. He tells Glen they need to go back into The Reach tonight and cross the river to uncover the truth behind the disappearances. Glen adamantly refuses knowing what this would entail but Chris' determination is unshakeable; he's going with or without Glen.

At a restaurant, Chris has lunch alone and is baffled to find Olivia, Glen's supposedly dead wife, performing Joan Baez's *Diamonds and Rust* on stage. Most of the crowd is unimpressed by her singing but Chris' disbelief

on seeing her makes him transfixed by her performance and when their eyes meet, he promptly leaves before finishing his meal. Feeling like he's slowly losing his sanity, he goes to Glen's apartment for some much needed clarifications. However, he isn't there so he goes to Maggie. Maggie, having known Glen for a long time, reveals Olivia never died and was never Glen's wife. Everything was just a fabrication by Glen to feed his own delusions. She reveals Glen was hopelessly obsessed with Olivia and her constant rejections pushed him to commit unspeakable horrors to her. This made her leave town years ago but her return now is somewhat mystifying. Maggie then tells Chris she knows from Glen that he is planning to cross the river and she wants to tag along. Chris obviously refuses but Maggie begs him to let her come since she feels intensely remorseful for her behavior towards Shawn and believes rescuing him from The Reach could be her definitive redemptive act. Relating with Maggie's turmoil and knowing it'd be better not to be alone on this journey, Chris reluctantly agrees to take her along. Of course, their whole trip beyond the river would have never been approved by any authorities so it must remain shrouded in secrecy.

In the afternoon, Chris is summoned into The Mayor's office after some shady documents were found inside a secret compartment in Paul's apartment. The documents, mostly sanitized, imply Paul was working for the CIA, much to Chris' bemusement, who knows Paul retired from service long ago and never had anything to do with the CIA. The Mayor lectures obstinately on the government's hubris and vanity in their attempts at uncovering the powers behind The Reach and using them for their own agenda. He calls The Reach a sacred place which should be kept far from men's greed and corruption. Chris' respect for The Mayor plummets further, after clearly sensing his hypocrisy. The Mayor feels that Chris is lying about his ignorance and has little trust in him.

At night at the power station, Glen has a change of heart and reunites with Chris and Maggie for their forthcoming journey. Old Albert, who somehow knows about their endeavor, warns them of **The Other Side**, which he refers to as an alternate world forbidden to humans but the trio don't pay heed to his warnings. Unbeknownst to them, Olivia is already inside the power station, having inexplicably fooled the security cameras and guards. She's alone, with no guide. At midnight, the mist arrives and everyone is transported into The Reach. At the river, Chris, Glen and Maggie swim to the other side and vanish amidst the trees. Their determination, curiosity, and perseverance are much stronger than their fear of not coming back.

Shortly later, Olivia wanders amidst the trees, unnoticed by the other visitors. She arrives at the river, removes all her clothes and seems to somehow be able to walk on water. She effortlessly strolls to the other side and sits down by a pond amidst the trees. She gazes at her own reflection in the water and becomes aroused by what she sees. Olivia, an autosexual, masturbates to the sight of her own reflection and just as she is about to orgasm, a deformed version of herself approaches her from behind, shouting her name. As Olivia eyeballs her doppelganger, the latter grabs a rock and bashes her head with it. She crumbles on the grass and the doppelganger metamorphoses into The Grease Monkey, who then picks up her unconscious body.

Meanwhile, Chris, Maggie and Glen trudge through the trees. Chris witnesses a flock of Blue Jays flying towards the setting sun and wonders whether the wildlife in The Reach is an image or not. Glen explains this has always been a mystery. Believing in Berkeley's subjective idealism, Glen believes The Reach cannot exist outside the

mind. He posits whoever created it has made its existence dependent on the presence of other minds to fabricate its contents through dreams and memories. But their malleability makes Chris question whether Glen's theory is true since The Reach would have taken a whole new appearance each time. But Glen retorts that The Reach's foundational elements (such as the multicolored sky and the forests) are byproducts of the collective unconscious, as Chris previously deduced, so they remain as constants.

Tired, the group decides to rest for the night. They dig into their food rations even though they are well aware none of it is real. But within this dream world, eating images still relieves hunger. Above them, the sky displays a breathtaking spectacle of auroras, painting the night with vibrant hues. Glen appears tense and alert, as though anticipating an event or, more specifically, someone's appearance. Chris, picking up on this, realizes Glen is awaiting Olivia and confronts him with the perplexing lie about Olivia being his deceased wife.

Embarrassed, Glen feels intensely shameful for his unhealthy fixation on Olivia. He expounds lengthily on how the jollier memories of her continue to linger in his mind which then fuel his obsession for her, an obsession he very knowingly mistakes for love. He reveals Olivia was an aspiring singer and also a prostitute. Their paths crossed when Glen became her most devoted client. When she abandoned prostitution at Glen's insistence, they shared a "loving" relationship. Glen was the only constant in Olivia's life, after her brother was killed during the War in Afghanistan. Suffering from severe body dysmorphia, she underwent plastic surgery. Afterwards, she began steadily distancing herself, eventually ignoring Glen altogether for richer men after Glen went broke from financing her surgery. Maggie is aware that Olivia only exploited Glen, yet Glen, trapped in his delusions, believes their connection was genuine. Maggie then tries to prompt him to tell Chris about the awful things he did to Olivia after she abandoned him, but Glen simply feigns ignorance.

Chris understands what Maggie's implying and is baffled to witness Glen's obliviousness to what he's done. Adopting a stance of detachment from the past, Glen chooses to forget any events that might stir negative emotions, like guilt or remorse, firmly believing in leaving such matters behind. To exemplify how detrimental lingering on traumatic past events is, Glen refers to the burning house and Chris' sister which they encountered during their last journey into The Reach. He knows this memory originates from Chris' unresolved feelings about the tragedy since the burning house was never there before. For Glen, this is why distancing oneself from such painful memories is better than needlessly dwelling on them.

Maggie fails to understand Glen's obsession with Olivia, someone who repeatedly used him, only to abandon him after Glen became useless to her. Similarly, Chris references their previous argument and his struggles at understanding Maggie's infidelity. She tries to justify her actions by continuously saying that she was simply dissatisfied with her relationship, which she felt was repetitive and boring. She describes her life with Shawn as plagued by poverty and loneliness, exacerbated by his frequent absences due to work commitments, even though Shawn made sure to frequently show his love for her. Shawn was sterile so Maggie couldn't have a child that is wholly theirs. Despite all her best efforts to rationalize her behavior, Chris isn't convinced. He lambasts her as simply being self-centered and selfish. Glen then claims Chris is no different; he came into The Reach only because he still hopes he will be reunited with his sister, Charlotte. By crossing the river, both Glen and Chris

hope to uncover the mysteries surrounding The Reach which can consequently bring them closer to Olivia and Charlotte.

Maggie disappointedly realizes the real reason Chris and Glen came into The Reach was not to find the missing individuals but to reunite with “loved” ones who are no longer in their lives. As tensions ease, the trio settles down for sleep. Chris, curious about the nature of sleep within this dream world, asks whether sleeping would transport them to another dream reality. Glen reassures him that sleep within The Reach is devoid of dreams, offering a rare moment of tranquility free from the idiosyncrasies of this place.

Roughly 4 hours later, the group wakes up due to the surprising cold. They are taken aback by snow cascading from the skies and Glen mentions how this is the first case of snow inside The Reach. As they carry on with their search through the forest, they stumble on lubricating oil, smeared across the ground. Almost immediately, Maggie spots the outline of a man observing them. The figure dashes away and the trio chases him. Amidst the trees, the figure reaches a building **identical** to the power station. Glen, knowing they are on the other side of the river, affirms this must be another power station. The figure disappears inside the building. The group, yearning for answers, follows the man inside before a strong gust of wind shuts the entrance doors behind them.

Interlude

On a gloomy day in a field surrounded by a forest, there is an isolated house. Bizarrely, a taxicab emerges from the forest despite the fact that we see no roads whatsoever behind the trees. From her son’s bedroom, Diane observes the taxi as it approaches the house. Her son, Joseph, is dying from an unspecified illness. Diane’s older son, revealed to be Chris, pleads with his mother to bring him to a doctor. But Diane, a Jehovah’s witness, rejects modern medicine and blames Chris’ lack of faith for his brother’s condition. Meanwhile, a hungry 10-year-old Charlotte, covered in bruises stemming from Diane’s physically abusive behavior, scours the kitchen for something to eat but finds nothing. A priest steps out of the taxi and Diane forcefully grabs Charlotte with her as she goes to greet him. The priest performs useless prayers and rites on Joseph, much to Chris’ frustration. Facing a mirror in Joseph’s bedroom, Chris encounters a strange anomaly: Instead of the face of a 14-year-old that he expects to see, he sees the reflection of his adult self. This makes him realize he is trapped in a memory. As he approaches Joseph’s bed to get a closer look at his brother, he finds him to be **faceless**. Chris is simply unable to recollect his brother’s face, who died when Chris was merely 14. Disturbed, he tries to leave but Diane instructs him to remain inside the room and her authoritativeness somehow paralyzes Chris, who becomes physically unable to move.

Part 2 - Streamgate

In a luxurious house in Streamgate town, Maggie impatiently awaits the results of her pregnancy test. When the pregnancy stick shows a clear positive result, she becomes elated. Her husband, Chris, returns from work and when Maggie relays the joyful news to him, Chris masquerades his indifference behind an artificial glee. Despite Maggie’s loving attitude, Chris seems glaringly unhappy at their marriage. Maggie is distraught by this but she keeps being affectionate with Chris, desperately trying to preserve their marriage.

The couple is visited by Chris' 70-years-old mother, Diane. She heavily disapproves of their marriage since Chris rejected the doctrines of being a Jehovah's witness and married a nonbeliever. She endlessly berates Maggie but Chris seldom comes to her defense. However, when Diane criticizes Chris' career in pharmaceuticals, he's quick to defend his work whilst lambasting Diane's beliefs. Diane's hypocrisy is showcased when it turns out she is a heavy smoker, which is prohibited by the denomination. Maggie calmly asks her to turn off her cigarette since she's pregnant and this revelation serves to further infuriate Diane, who resentfully tells Chris he'll fail to care for the child just like he failed to care for his little sister. Enraged, Chris asks her to leave. Before going, Diane leaves him a present which he doesn't even bother opening. His mother's visit expectedly tainted Chris' mood and when Maggie offers to comfort him, he ignores her and goes to the local bar.

There, he strikes a conversation with the bartender, who looks exactly like The Grease Monkey. He laments lengthily on his mother's hateful behavior before expressing his true feelings about Maggie's pregnancy. He calls their marriage boring and unfulfilling and a child will just be an additional burden for him. He also expresses a distaste for his work, which he calls monotonous and repetitive. Finally, he admits to the bartender that he has been seeing other people to fulfill his sexual needs. The bartender seems to readily empathize with Chris and even recommends a brothel called *The Red Nights Club*.

At night, Chris goes there and entrusts the Madam with providing him with her best prostitute. After waiting in a lavish red-painted bedroom, Olivia comes in and Chris is beyond baffled. He inconceivably refers to her as Charlotte, his sister whom he believed was forever lost to him. He bursts into tears of joy whilst hugging her and Olivia also somehow sees Chris as Dean, her brother she thought had died. Chris, saddened that Olivia (Charlotte to him) had to resort to prostitution, offers her a new life with him. Meanwhile, Maggie goes shopping and buys some expensive items using Chris' hard-earned money. After that, she goes to a gloomy and filthy apartment building where she meets Glen (who she refers to as Alex). Glen here is a heroin addict and becomes infuriated to find that Maggie (who he refers to as Olivia) only brought him a small amount of heroin. Despite Glen's persistently abusive attitude towards Maggie, she is somehow hopelessly in love with him. He then forces her to shoot heroin with him, after which they both drift into a drug-induced haze.

At around midnight, Maggie returns home where a delighted Chris introduces her to Olivia. Maggie is indifferent to the siblings' reunion and proceeds to go to bed whilst Chris starts to wonder about Maggie's frequent absences. It's quite awkward between Chris and Olivia, both haven't gotten comfortable with each other yet but Chris repeatedly promises that Olivia's lifestyle will considerably improve thanks to him. She expresses regret and self-loathing for her years spent as a prostitute but Chris consoles her that she did what she had to do to survive. Alone in the guest bedroom, Olivia watches herself naked in front of the mirror and proceeds to smear lipstick all over her body whilst repeatedly calling herself repulsive and worthless in a self-loathing rant.

Next morning, Maggie rejoins Glen at his apartment and is coerced to consume all kinds of psychedelics with him. Maggie implores him to move out of town with her so that they can start their lives somewhere else together but just then, Glen is struck by a vision: He finds himself violently throwing a **faceless** woman into the

floor in a dark room before climbing on top of her and raping her. After witnessing this atrocity, he repeatedly screams, "I did not do this! I did not do this!" to a confused Maggie. He breaks down in tears and laments the fact that this recurring vision has been haunting him for quite a while now. Maggie embraces him, puzzled but still trying to offer him some comfort.

Meanwhile, Chris regrets his behavior towards his mother during her visit, blatantly ignoring that she was the one who initiated their argument. He phones her but a deep menacing voice answers the call. The voice informs him that Diane is sick and has been admitted to the hospital. The unknown man then blames Chris for Diane's condition and asks, "Wasn't killing your sister enough?" Deeply disturbed, Chris hangs up and opens the gift Diane had given him. It's a perfume with a disturbing scent: burnt human flesh. Revolted, Chris throws it away and sprays the house with air freshener to get rid of the smell.

Later during the day, Chris drives Olivia to a singing audition at the town's Art and Culture hall. When it finally becomes her turn to perform on stage, she is ridiculed by the 3 judges. Their faces are obscured by an eerie darkness and they each have the voice of The Grease Monkey. Nevertheless, she performs the song "*Diamonds and Rust*" and afterwards, one judge simply says "Next!" without even giving her any feedback. Interpreting that they didn't like her performance, she asks how she can improve. After a long silence, one judge recommends to her the *Aurelia Academy*, a singing school found at an address given to her on a piece of paper.

In the afternoon, a disgruntled Olivia returns home where she has a chat with Maggie. She talks about her lifelong dream of becoming a renowned pop star and that reuniting with her brother was the first glimmer of hope since he left her life. Maggie asks how they got reunited and Olivia unknowingly slips out that they came across each other at *The Red Nights Club*. Realizing Chris has been unfaithful, Maggie becomes furious. He tells Olivia how she always showed Chris affection and love during the 3 years of their marriage but he still never cared for her. But as she calms down, she reveals she too is seeing someone else.

At night, Chris gulps down another glass of whiskey before again rambling to the bartender about how dissatisfied and bored he is of his life. He thought reuniting with his sister would change things but he is still plagued by an unquenchable sense of unfulfillment and imprisonment. Meanwhile, Glen is again tormented by the recurring vision, condemned to relive it over and over again.

Next morning, Olivia travels to the address and finds a butcher shop instead. She asks the butcher, The Grease Monkey but this time fat and covered in sweat, about the *Aurelia Academy*. The butcher instructs her to follow him into the meat cold storage to "realize her dreams". She obviously refuses but he grabs her and brutally flings her inside. She carries her to an extremely dark alley in the back where we find the neon sign "Aurelia Academy" in front of a dilapidated door. He opens it and locks her inside. The lights are turned on and she finds herself inside a room with a dozen of young and pretty well-dressed women. They ominously announce she won't be able to escape and then start to mock her appearance and voice. They keep on ridiculing her with gusts of insults until Olivia breaks down in tears. The lights start to flicker, further plunging her into a nightmarish despair.

Meanwhile, Chris is quietly watching TV when Maggie tries to have sex with him, much to his annoyance. He rejects her advances and tells her he's bored with making love to her. Maggie, dejected, gets in her newly bought dress and tries to leave. Chris blocks off the door and asks where she is going after having dressed herself so elegantly. She claims she's heading to the mall but Chris isn't convinced. As she drives away, Chris secretly follows her. When she reaches her destination, Chris pads upstairs to Glen's apartment room, following Maggie from a safe distance. Maggie is beyond infuriated to find another woman giving Glen a blowjob. She violently kicks her out whilst Chris eavesdrops on the scene. She reiterates his love for Glen and screams how she doesn't understand why Glen, who she thinks previously loved her, has now changed his mind about her. Exasperated, Glen reveals the truth: He never loved Maggie (Olivia for him) and only used her to finance his drug addiction. She finally reveals that the child she is carrying is Glen's (Alex's for her). Chris was abroad when she got impregnated 3 months ago which is why she hid from Chris the age of the fetus. A dejected Chris can no longer bear to hear all this and quietly leaves. Glen, perturbed and angry, says he no longer wants Maggie in her life and begs her to leave. Again, she reaffirms her love for him but this only makes Glen angrier. He beats her in the stomach, grabs her and throws her out of his room, making sure to lock the door.

At the *Aurelia Academy*, Olivia, no longer able to endure the vicious insults from these mean-spirited women, grabs a chair and breaks open the door she came in. She then finds herself in a labyrinthine network of corridors whilst she's being chased by the women. She encounters Old Albert, who guides her to another door which leads her to a dark stage. A spotlight illuminates her from above and she's now inexplicably in the town's Art and Culture hall with the 3 judges. They ask her to perform and Olivia, distraught by these events, breaks down onstage. She cries that she's talentless, self-centered and narcissistic and lengthily expounds on how manipulative and self-obsessed she really is. After her self-hating speech, the lights are switched on and a large audience gives her a standing ovation. Amidst the lengthy cheers and applause, she displays a relieved and victorious smile.

Maggie, still in tears, intentionally crashes her car against a tree. Injured, she leaves the vehicle and throws up, suffering from severe abdominal pain. Her vomit is marred with blood. Suddenly, a deformed, bloodied and monstrous fetus crawls out of her vagina as she screams in terror. Meanwhile, Chris goes to visit Diane at the hospital. When he asks what the doctor told her, she simply tells him, "I'm dying from the fire." She condemns Chris for burning their family house down decades ago, unaware that a 12-year-old Charlotte was inside. Chris tries to tell her his sister is back but Diane, somehow aware of his recent experiences, tells him he's mistaken and that he has brought a complete stranger into his house. To validate her claims, she asks Chris to look at the window. The view of the city transforms into a **flashback** of a 16-year-old Chris setting fire to the family house unbeknownst that his sister, who should have been at school, is inside. As the fire begins engulfing the house, a desperate Charlotte tries to find a way out but she suffers an asthma attack from smoke inhalation and her unconscious body is burnt alive. Chris begs Diane to stop the scene but she feels a sadistic satisfaction in witnessing Chris' anguish at what he's seeing. She rationalized Chris' actions as a show of hate at her and God; to prove God is powerless against all the evil in the world. She claims Chris replaced Charlotte with Olivia to make peace with himself but the truth always triumphs, even at the expense of Chris' sanity.

But to Diane's puzzlement, Chris turns to her with a determined gaze. Remembering the past made Chris question if the Diane in this hospital bed is even his mother. Diane, confused and angered, asks Chris to explain himself. As it turns out, recollecting the past made Chris realize his mother actually died 6 years ago. Looking sternly at her, he expounds on how he always chose rationality over his mother's delusions. Finally, he proclaims, "You're not real." Diane then bursts into flames, screaming as the fire consumes her, whilst Chris leaves, having finally vanquished his mother or whoever that person was.

Glen, suffering from severe withdrawal symptoms, tries to call Maggie for money. She fails to answer his calls prompting him to go to her place. He knocks at the doors and Olivia answers. Neither recognize each other. He asks to see "Olivia" and Olivia replies, "That's me." Befuddled and deeply disturbed, he eyeballs her before leaving hurriedly. Whilst going through the sidewalk back to his apartment, the vision strikes again but this time his mysterious victim has a face and it's Olivia's (the real one).

Maggie, still traumatized by her recent ordeals, returns home with blood all over her and Chris, indifferent to all that, wonders if she's really his wife. Chris realizes reality has somehow been altered but the overpowering rage stemming from the fact that Maggie cheated on him, regardless if this world is real or not, causes him to beat her down to a pulp. As Maggie screams for help, Chris holds her down on the floor and brutally rapes her. But in an inconceivable turn of events, the skin of Chris' face opens up like a cocoon resulting in huge amounts of blood gushing from his head. He then metamorphoses into Glen. Similarly, Maggie metamorphoses into Olivia. Still on top of her, Glen realizes he just raped her. The real Maggie wakes up next to the corpse of the real Alex, with a bullet hole in his forehead. She screams in horror before being comforted by the appearance of her husband. This time, it's the real Shawn. She promises she will always be by his side if ever he comes back to her for good. Again, Chris finds himself in the blazing house of his childhood, right next to an unconscious Charlotte in flames. He tries to douse the fire but it's too late.

After their traumatic experiences, Chris, Maggie, Glen and Olivia find themselves at the power station in front of a stage. Amidst the confusion, sadness and terror, a facially deformed and obese woman arrives on stage and performs "*Diamonds and Rust*". Her tender voice hypnotizes them and they all share a quiet moment of serenity. After her performance, the woman and the stage vanish. Olivia glares at Glen, horrified and disgusted. He desperately tries to talk to her but she vanishes. One by one, Olivia, Chris, Maggie and Glen fade away from the power station.

Part 3 - The Other Side

At night in a hospital, back in Rivermouth, Chris regains consciousness but suffers from sleep paralysis. All he can see is a mysterious silhouette standing beside him for an unconformable amount of time before vanishing. Shortly later, a nurse notices that Chris' eyes are wide open and alerts her colleagues.

In the morning, a miracle has occurred: Chris, Glen and Maggie have regained consciousness after spending nearly one year in a coma. This time frame didn't match the time they spent in Streamgate, which basically felt like a whole lifetime. A concerned Maggie asks Captain Ross if Shawn has also woken up but that's sadly not the

case. Paul's family lost all hope that he'll ever come back and requested that his life support be disconnected. Glen realizes Olivia is nowhere to be seen and Ross says no one matching Olivia's description was seen coming in or out of the power station back then. Glen, desperate to find her again, wants to mobilize a team to return to The Reach but Ross tells the trio that after their disappearances, the power station was closed down and The Mayor had to resign. Chris seems cautiously happy to hear this but asks why it wasn't demolished. Ross suspects the government still wants to be able to access it for research purposes.

A team of government officials will be coming to Rivermouth in a few days to question the trio on their experiences inside The Reach. Outside the hospital, Chris sits down in silence with a lugubrious Glen, both morosely pondering on their lives at Streamgate town. Meanwhile, Maggie sobs besides Shawn's unconscious body. After contemplating lengthily, the heartbroken Maggie realizes that it would be best to disconnect her husband from his life support after finally accepting that she will never see him again. Since he has no close family members, it's her decision. She dries her tears and kisses him on the forehead. She's comforted by the thoughts that allowing him to die peacefully will free him from the malicious grip of The Reach and save him from the dreadful experiences she went through.

Afterwards, she rejoins Chris and Glen outside and the feelings of anger, distrust, sadness and confusion permeate their minds. Chris apologizes to Maggie for what he did to her but Maggie understands that none of them were truly themselves inside The Reach, as if they were playing each other in a play or a movie. Regardless, she still feels resentment and revulsion at Chris' actions, even if she knows the real Chris would never act like that. Chris tries to rationalize the events as a projection of one's unconscious desires, mindset and drives into another who didn't understand these aspects of their personality. Through experience, these make Chris reflect on his own lack of understanding of those he judged. Maggie warns him that this doesn't justify the heinousness of their actions since understanding one's wicked behavior shouldn't equal to condoning it. Chris theorizes The Reach substituted one's **Self** with another's **shadow** leading to unrestrained and immoral behaviors. Furthermore, **wish-fulfillment** was a major part of their experiences and yet, their lives remained miserable.

Glen, however, believes attributing meaning to their experiences is a waste of time. Like **Camus**, he believes in the absurd nature of human existence and that dreams are just as preposterous. But Chris believes Glen is unconsciously searching for meaning in his life through his obsession for Olivia. Being with her or even making peace with her is what gives meaning to Glen's lonely and loveless life. Chris, as always, tries to seek rational explanations to the **manifest content** of their dream world through the exploration of its **latent content**. Decrypting the latter will give them a better understanding of their own psyche. But Glen believes all this is a wild goose chase. He mentions **Schopenhauer's Will**, the fact that the Will, an irrational, blind, and ceaseless drive that underlies all existence, is responsible for why their dream existence in Streamgate town was so depraved. Their lives there were powered by impulses and messed up desires without the influence of the **Ego** or **Superego** to keep them at bay.

Maggie is revolted by Glen's words, as it's quite obvious he is merely trying to defend his actions through intellectualization. However Chris doesn't understand why and how The Reach did what it did and it's this lack

of comprehension that becomes a tormenting presence in his mind. His search for answers led to a deadend with more questions now than ever before. Throughout his life, he tried to adopt **Kant's Categorical Imperative** for all his actions but in The Reach, he was simply someone else; someone immoral and vile. How? And why? The trio is too embarrassed to discuss the specifics of their actions and Glen decides to conclude their meetup, reassured by the fact he won't have to deal with Chris or Maggie again.

After spending so long in Streamgate, reality is strangely alienating for the three. At night, Chris drowns his sorrows at a bar and is approached by Old Albert. Chris expresses his regrets that he didn't pay heed to Old Albert's warnings about the other side of the river. Old Albert mysteriously comments that he wasn't referring to the river, having even forgotten there was a river in The Reach. Instead, **The Other Side** is someplace else. Old Albert then goes to a dark alley where, amidst the rain and thunder, he removes the skin from his face with his bare hands, revealing The Grease Monkey under the old man's face. He then walks away into the night while lightning flashes across the sky.

A few days later, Chris prepares to leave Rivermouth. Still perturbed by his alternate life inside The Reach and longing for answers, he feels strangely conflicted about leaving it all behind. Meanwhile, Glen took the most readily available job as a low-paid janitor. Likewise, Maggie serves as a waitress at a restaurant. They hate the monotony and meaninglessness of their jobs but that's all they have. The trio have all succumbed to depression with Glen even planning to end his life today. He buys a gun from a dealer and returns home.

In the afternoon, Glen bursts into tears whilst grieving the loss of Olivia and feeling the intense guilt from the horrible things he did to her. The past finally came to haunt him and he can't take it anymore. Just as he's about to commit the irrevocable, a hand lands on his shoulder. It's Olivia, alive and well. Glen simply can't believe his eyes: Is this real? How can this be real? Olivia tells him she's here for him now before removing her clothes and unclothing Glen as well. They embrace each other and make passionate love. They levitate above the bed before the room inexplicably catches fire. The heat doesn't seem to bother them and the flames quickly engulf them both.

Meanwhile, Maggie wanders around the area of the power station, now heavily guarded. From afar, she is overwhelmed by grief and revisits the brief moment she spent with Shawn inside The Reach. She wonders whether his consciousness somehow still lives on inside this dream world when suddenly, her husband incomprehensibly emerges from the trees. She hugs him tearfully, completely oblivious as to whether or not this is reality. She promises to spend the rest of his life with him and Shawn takes her hand and guides her inside the power station, both invisible to the guards.

At night, Captain Ross calls Chris at his hotel room to inform him that his flight will depart in 2 hours. Still overwhelmed by his thirst for answers, Chris grabs a gun and drives to the forest. Hiding from the patrols, he makes his way towards the power station but seeing how guarded it is, he has little chance of getting inside unless he creates a massive diversion. Chris, dead set on finding the answers to his raging questions, blows up a car with gunfire before storming towards the power station, chased by the guards. He goes to the Stygian basement tunnel where he remembers the strange sounds he heard at the other side of the left turn. He goes there and sees

nothing: It's a dead-end. He hears someone approaching and he cocks his pistol before hiding behind the wall. The footsteps grow closer and closer until he hears a familiar voice, "Chris, it's time!" The footsteps fade away, leaving Chris deeply puzzled as he realizes what this means. He wonders what would have happened if he had confronted his past self, had Glen not called for him. He doesn't even have time to process what just happened when a red door materializes in front of him. Determined to get to the bottom of all this, he opens it and walks into **The Other Side**:

He finds himself in an alley in another town during a sunny day. This is neither Rivermouth nor Streamgate and the door he crossed is gone. Confused, he wonders if he is in The Reach but the town looks strangely too ordinary. The pedestrians are peaceful and joyous and the weather, calm and pleasant. Chris, who came looking for answers, is crestfallen to confront even more questions.

He scans his surroundings lengthily as he wanders through the streets in a state of disorientation. He stumbles on a cozy cafe and simply orders some food. Realizing his obsession for answers is getting ridiculous, he decides to eat silently, too speechless and hungry to ask anyone where exactly he is. A car parks outside and out comes Paul Myles. Chris nearly chokes on his food on seeing him. Paul enters the cafe and he looks perfectly fine and normal. Chris approaches him in bewilderment and disbelief. Paul recognises him and asks about his wife and kids. Chris was never married and definitely doesn't have kids so what's going on? Paul apologizes for missing Chris' son's birthday party last week, which further sends Chris in a spiral of confusion.

Chris begs to know what became of Paul, Shawn and the third man when they crossed the river but Paul, perplexed by his questions, insists he doesn't even know these two men or the river he's referring to. As strange as it sounds, Chris now wants Paul to drive him to his own place. Since Chris seems to have a family in this reality, he must have a house somewhere. Paul accepts but just as they enter his car, Paul pulls a handgun and fires at Chris. Chris dodges the bullets, kicks Paul and snatches off his gun. With the tables turned, Chris holds Paul at gunpoint as he drives him to the other Chris' place. During the ride, Chris begs for answers about Paul's whereabouts since his disappearance. Paul simply replies that he isn't the Paul he knew. When Chris inquires about The Grease Monkey, Paul promises that he'll understand what's going on upon reaching their destination.

They reach a small but beautiful suburban house where Chris, gun aimed forward, encounters a woman and 2 kids who think he's their father. Chris tells them that he doesn't know any of them but shortly later, a car comes into the driveway and out comes Chris' **doppelganger**. His doppelganger looks exactly like him; same size, same height, same face, same everything. The doppelganger seems to immediately understand the situation, and promises Chris that the answers to his questions will be revealed.

Chris lowers his weapon and they have a discussion. The doppelganger tells his wife and kids to go upstairs, even saying that they have prepared for this eventuality and the key is to remain calm. The doppelganger explains that they have constructed a quasi-utopia through information gathered from The Reach and each of them are playing a role, like in a play or a movie. Chris fails to grasp this. Who's "they"? Did "they" create The Reach? Where is Chris exactly right now? The lack of concrete answers is sending Chris to the precipice of insanity. He

becomes violent and starts throwing things around like a frustrated child. At this moment, the doppelganger realizes that the only way for Chris to understand the truth is to show it to him by leaving town. Chris asks to know the destination but the doppelganger remains frustratingly cryptic.

Chris doesn't trust him but his craving for answers is like a drug to him. The doppelganger kisses his wife and kids goodbye before getting into the car with Chris for their road trip. During their journey, Chris and the doppelganger have a chat. Chris asks to know if they are in The Reach but the doppelganger says that technically, they are in a **product** of The Reach. He describes The Reach as being a sentient mirror and a sort of laboratory. He affirms he isn't Chris despite looking exactly like him; he needed an image and was chosen to bear his. He comments how no one in this world is in their true physical form. Their goal is to understand humanity by reflecting the psyche of everyone who crosses the river onto other visitors on the "doomed" side of the river to shed some light on mankind's many issues, such as our inability to understand each other. Chris looks askance at him, he wants his answers to be much clearer and elaborate but the doppelganger promises that once they reach their destination, he'll understand everything. Chris still carries his gun in case things go south. He wonders if all this is a product of his unconscious; the doppelganger could be Chris' wish-fulfillment of getting married and having kids. The doppelganger rebuffs his theory, saying he's many things but definitely not a part of Chris' mind. Chris tells his doppelganger that he is wasting his time trying to understand humanity and should focus on finding flaws within his own kind. But the doppelganger simply answers that's not how "they" function as Chris will find out once the two reach their destination.

The night falls and they're still on the road. Chris notices that the mountains look familiar right as they go by a town sign where it's written: Rivermouth. This greatly alarms Chris, who thought they are in a different world and therefore the presence of Rivermouth seems inexplicable. The doppelganger reassures him that the real Charlotte is waiting for him and soon they'll be reunited. Hearing this sends Chris in a frantic state. Charlotte being alive means all of this is not reality but merely an illusory world just like The Reach. Unwilling to accept an unreal existence, he gets into a heated argument with his doppelganger and begs him to allow him to return to reality. The doppelganger doesn't understand him since reuniting with Charlotte would make him happy and be a cure to his sorrowful life but Chris is firmly rooted on the fact that he does NOT want to live in an illusion. The doppelganger retaliates by stating how Chris' reality has always been dreadful so why not live in a more comforting reality but Chris' commitment to rationality and the real is unshakeable. He tries to seize control of the vehicle but ultimately causes it to skid off road and crash into the trees.

The impact was so violent that the car is now upside down. Chris is unconscious and the doppelganger drags his body out of the wreckage. After a long wait, a car arrives and the doppelganger enters it with Chris' body. The driver doesn't speak a word, as if knowing perfectly well what happened. They reach a forest where ominous lights flicker through the trees, all stemming from the infamous power station, which is bizarrely emitting heartbeat sounds. The doppelganger exits the car with Chris' body and hands it over to The Grease Monkey. The Grease Monkey, with Chris in his arms, walks into the power station whilst a mist slowly begins to engulf the building. The strange lights flicker even brighter, penetrating through the dense mist. After a while, the mist begins to fade away and the power station vanishes, as if it never existed.

The End